



Guggenheim Museum Bilbao

An art museum that is itself also a sculpture—a building that rejuvenated a city in decline

Hailed as the most influential work of architecture in the second half of the 20th century, Frank Gehry's groundbreaking contemporary art museum was commissioned in the early 1990s to reinject life and cultural vitality into the once-thriving port of Bilbao, northern Spain. Its doors opened in 1997.

Perspectives on a city

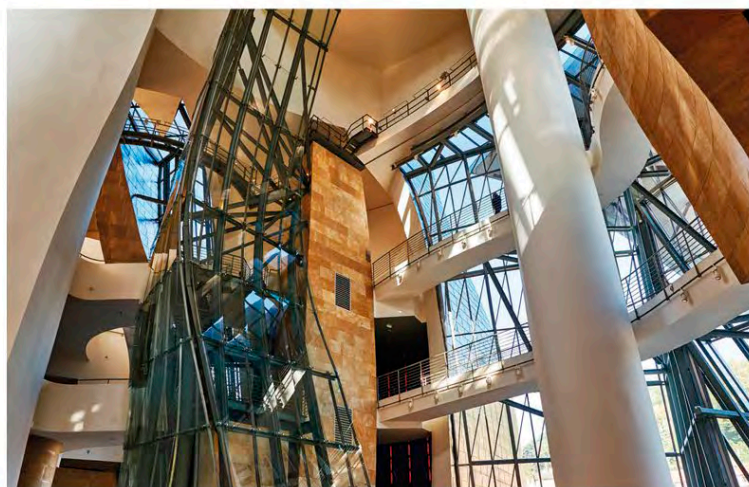
The Canadian-born US architect made full use of the site's industrial urban context and its riverside location: from one perspective, with the city as a backdrop, it presents right angles and windows, combined with stone; from another view, with the Nervión River in the foreground, more fluid, undulating

shapes harmonize with the surrounding water. In outline, the structure alludes to a ship, with curved panels suggesting sails, its titanium-clad exterior changing color according to the light and weather conditions. A metal flower adorns the highest point.

With 20 galleries on three levels, the massive structure combines titanium, glass, and limestone in an audacious experiment with volumes and perspectives. All the galleries converge on a large central atrium, which acts as the organizing heart of the museum.

Gehry's masterpiece has redefined Bilbao, bringing not only visual and cultural impact but also millions of visitors—and with them, considerable economic growth.

Fishlike forms appear around the building, such as **glass scales** that conceal stairs and elevators



◁ THE EXTERIOR

Magnificent curves and undulating forms in titanium, limestone, and glass define the museum's exterior, creating a modern space of immense force and originality.

△ CIRCULATION HUB

The monumental atrium—with its soaring shapes in steel, glass, limestone, and plaster, intersected by horizontal walkways—forms the heart of the museum.

THE ATRIUM

The magnificent atrium in the museum, a hall of curved volumes and twisting glass and steel, reaches a height of 164 ft (50 m). This vast empty space, flooded with light, acts as a central point from which the museum's various rooms, halls, and pathways can be accessed.

